

HONG KONG MAHJONG

A Beginner's Guide



VICTORIA
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域多利華麻雀協會

About Mahjong

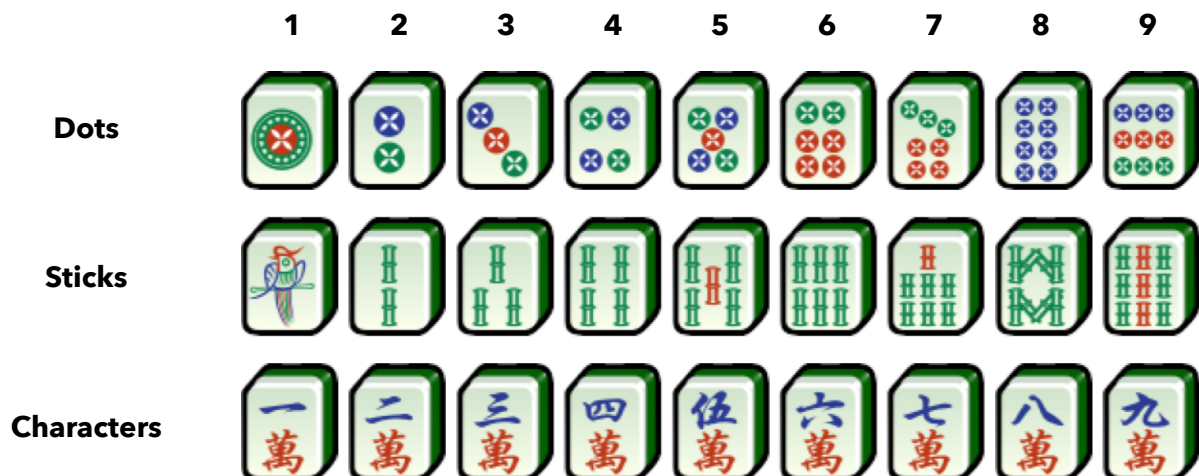
Mahjong is a tile-based game similar to Rummy played in much of East and Southeast Asia, originating sometime during the Qing dynasty. There's many different regional versions, but this guide is based on the Hong Kong style.

Mahjong is a gambling game, but we usually play for chips or just for fun. It's a tactile and interesting game that depends on both luck and skill for success, and a Mahjong table is a great place to socialize and connect with others.

The Tiles

Hong Kong Mahjong Uses 144 Tiles, made up of three **suits**, **honour tiles** and **flowers**.

The Three Suits (4 of each tile)



Honour Tiles (4 of each tile)



Winds are valuable if they match the round wind or your seat wind. Dragons are valuable all the time!

Flowers (1 of each tile)



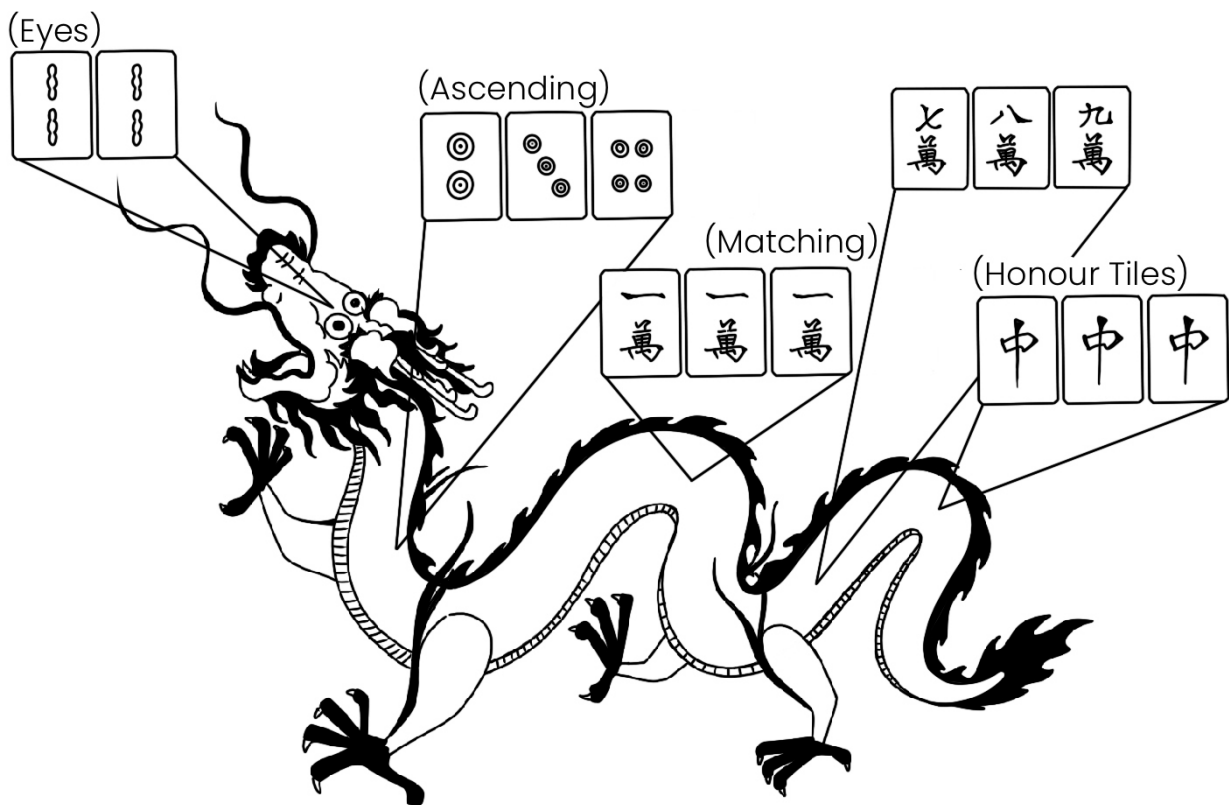
These are "bonus" tiles that may give you points. There are 4 flowers and 4 seasons, but we call them all "flowers"

Game Objective

The objective of the game is to be the first to build a 14-tile “dragon” consisting of **4 sets and a pair**.

Sets can be formed two ways:

1. **Sequences** of exactly three ascending tiles of a single suit (dots, sticks or characters)
2. **Triplets** (or quadruplets) of identical tiles.



You get **fan points** based on how nice your “dragon” looks, and the more fan points you get, the more chips you earn. How to earn these fan points will be discussed later.

Minimum Fan Points Requirements...?

*Hong Kong Mahjong players typically play with a **additional 3 fan point minimum** requirement in order to win. We usually don't apply that requirement for learning players – but you should be aware it exists.*

Game Flow

Mahjong is a game that is played in four **rounds**. Each round is made up of four or more **hands**, and the round is complete once all four players have been the dealer.

Each round represents one of the four winds. The first round is East, followed by South, West and North.

The job of dealer passes to the player on the right only if the dealer loses the hand, which means if your dealer is on a winning streak they could stay dealer for multiple hands!

You start a game by selecting a dealer, and then play hands until all four rounds have been played, or whenever everyone is tired, whichever comes first. Whoever has the most chips wins!

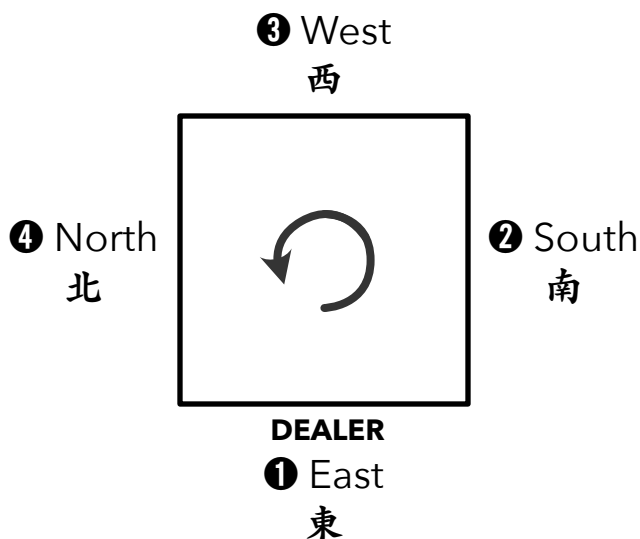
A hand of mahjong is played in three phases:

1. **Preparation** (the equivalent of shuffling and dealing cards)
2. **Playing the hand** until a player declares a win or you run out of tiles
3. **Payment** to the winner (unless there is a draw)

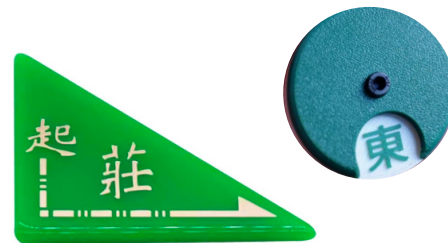
Determine the Initial Dealer

There's a few common ways of selecting the initial dealer:

1. Simply start with the youngest player
2. Players each roll 2 or 3 dice; the highest roll is the dealer.
3. Pull out one of each wind tile from the set, place them face down and shuffle them. The player who selects East is the dealer. The other three players sit as indicated below.



4. The dealer takes the dice, the round wind indicator (which should be set to East 東) and, if your set includes it, a round start triangle which you stick in the corner to indicate who was the first dealer.



Playing Mahjong

Play starts when the dealer (with 14 tiles) discards a tile into the centre of the table.

Players take turns in a counter-clockwise direction. Each player draws a new tile into their hand and discards an unwanted tile from their hand until they build a "complete hand."

When a player discards, other players may be able to immediately take the discard to "meld" a set with two or more tiles in their hand. When this happens, the order of play may skip other players' turns!

Play continues until a player builds a complete hand of 13 tiles plus either a tile they drew from the wall or that another player discarded.

If nobody completes their hand before the wall has been used up, the hand is considered a *draw*.

On Your Turn

1. If you have any quadruplets, you can "Kong" them now (see "*Making Kongs*" below)
2. Draw a tile from the "live" end of the wall.
3. If the tile is a flower, or completes a quadruplet, then declare the flower or make a Kong and choose a replacement tile from the "dead" end of the wall. Repeat this step as necessary.
4. If the drawn tile completes your hand, declare a self-pick win with a hearty "Ji Mo!" and reveal your hand to the table! Congratulations!
5. If you don't have a complete hand, select a tile to discard, and place it in the centre of the table.

Making Kongs...

There are two cases where you can declare a Kong on your turn:

1. *You have four concealed identical tiles in your hand. This is called a "Concealed Kong".*
2. *You have a declared Pong and you just drew the fourth matching tile from the wall. This is called a "Promoted Kong"*

In both cases, you declare the Kong, reveal the tiles (or add the fourth tile), and draw a replacement tile from the "dead" wall.

When revealing a Concealed Kong, put the two middle tiles face-down to indicate that this is concealed.

On Other Player's Turns

When another player discards a tile, you can "meld" that tile with two or more of your own to create a completed set.

In the case of any meld, after performing the steps you discard a tile and play continues in a counter-clockwise direction.

- 1. KONG (Quadruplet)** – If you have three identical tiles hidden in your hand, and any player discards the fourth tile, you can meld that tile by:
 - a. Announcing that you are performing a "Kong"
 - b. Take the discard and the three other tiles from your hand, and place the four tiles face up so all players can see.
 - c. Draw a replacement tile from the "dead" wall (which ensures you have the correct number of tiles in your hand.)
- 2. PONG (Triplet)** – If you have two identical tiles hidden in your hand, and any player discards a third tile, you can meld that tile by:
 - a. Announcing that you are performing a "Pong"
 - b. Take the discard and the two other tiles from your hand, and place the three tiles face up so all players can see.
- 3. SEUNG (Sequence)** – If you have two tiles of the same suit in your hand, and the player to your left discards a third tile of the same suit that makes a sequence of three consecutive tiles, you can meld that tile by:
 - a. Announcing that you are performing a "Seung"
 - b. Take the discard and the two other tiles from your hand, and place the three tiles face up so all players can see.
 - ⚠ You can only make a sequence from the player to your left!
 - ⚠ No wrap arounds! Sequences must be 1-2-3 to 7-8-9 but NOT 9-1-2!
 - ⚠ All tiles must be the same suit!
 - ⚠ Winds and dragons cannot be formed into a sequence!
- 4. SIK WU (Winning on a Discard)** – If you have a "Ready" hand (i.e. You can win if you get one more tile to complete a set or your pair), and any player discards one of the tiles you need, you can declare a win with a hearty "Sik Wu!" and reveal your hand to the table. Congratulations!
- 5. CHEUNG GONG (Robbing the Kong)** – If you have a "Ready" hand (i.e. You can win if you get one more tile to complete a set or your pair), and any player declares a Kong, of the tile you need to win, you can take that Kong'ed tile and declare a "Sik Wu!" Reveal your hand to the table. Congratulations!

Scoring

Overview

If you have won, congratulations! It's time to figure out how many chips you've earned.

You calculate the value of your hand based on the number of **fan points** it contains. Roughly speaking, every fan point doubles the value of the hand, all the way up to 13 fan points!

If you look at the "**Hong Kong Mahjong Rule Sheet**" included with this guide, there are a multitude of ways to earn fan points. All the patterns on the Rule Sheet can be stacked unless they are 13 fan patterns (called Special Hands) or are indented (e.g. when you count a Full Flush, you don't count the lesser Half Flush)

If you won on another player's discard, that player is responsible for paying you all the chips. If you self-draw the winning tile, however, everyone needs to pay up! See the Payment Table on the Rule Sheet for more specifics.

Round and Seat Winds

Not all winds are valuable to your hand. Making a triplet of your round wind or seat wind is worth 1 fan, or 2 fan if it is both the round AND the seat wind. Here's how to figure out which are valuable to you.

Round Wind

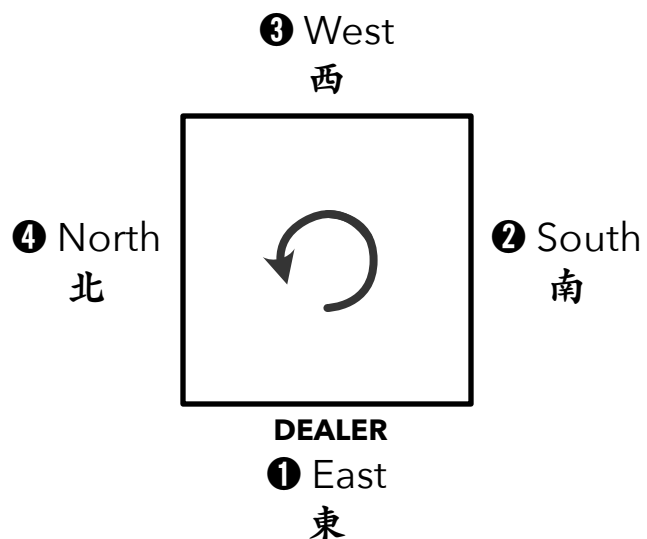
Just look at the Round Wind Indicator that the Dealer has to tell what wind is the current round wind. Mahjong always starts on the East 東 round, but once it returns to the initial dealer, they will change the round wind indicator to the next wind in the sequence. The sequence is:

East 東 → South 南 → West 西 → North 北.

Seat Wind

Your seat wind is determined by who the current Dealer is. As the Dealer changes, so does your seat wind.

For example, if the Dealer is sitting to your left, you are player number 2 which is South.



Flowers and Seasons

(For brevity, I'll refer to these all as "Flowers".)

All the Flower tiles feature a number from 1 to 4. These numbers are associated to your Seat number, where East = 1, South = 2, West = 3 and North = 4. *(Notice a trend?)*

Therefore if you're sitting in the West seat, the Flower tiles with the number 3 (in either Chinese or Arabic) are considered your "Seat Flowers".

Furthermore, you'll note on the Rule Sheet, you'll see that having NO Flowers is worth 1 fan, but having your Seat Flower is also worth 1 fan. What does this mean?

It means that you might start out with 1 Fan if you don't have any Flowers... But if you draw a flower that is NOT your seat, you will lose that 1 Fan. However, if you draw your Seat Flowers, each one is worth 1 Fan.

You also get points if you complete all the Flowers, all the Seasons, or even get 7 or all 8 tiles! See the Rule Sheet for more details.

Concealed vs Open Hands

Your hand is considered "Concealed" until you meld another player's tile with a Pong, Kong or Seung, after which it is considered to be "Open."

If you declare a Concealed Kong, your hand is still considered to be Concealed.

A Concealed Hand is still Concealed if you win on another player's Discard.

Get ready for another hand!

Once chips have been paid, it's time to play again!

If someone other than the Dealer won the hand, the Dealer moves to the next player to the right. If that next player is the Initial Dealer, it means you are playing the next round and the Round Wind Indicator should be updated at this time.

If the round ended in a Draw, the Dealer stays the same.

Either way, knock down any remaining wall, and start the next hand!

Credits

This guide was assembled by Daniel Ross, and includes the following:

- Illustration and text derived from “Tea Bases’s Mahjong Instruction Booklet”. Tea Base is a community arts space in Toronto’s Chinatown Centre Mall, who happen to also teach Mahjong.
<https://moca.ca/programmes/residency/tea-base-in-residence-at-moca/>
- “Hand with Pointing Finger” from Freepik:
https://www.freepik.com/free-vector/hand-with-pointing-finger_767002.htm
- Wikipedia (including rule clarifications and tile artwork)
- The Mahjong Subreddit, who scours every guide I write for errors and poor language
<https://www.reddit.com/r/mahjong>

About the Victoria Mahjong Club

The Victoria Mahjong Club is a regular meetup of mahjong players in the Victoria, BC area, organized and run by Daniel and Mannie Ross. Started in 2024, the club’s goals are to provide regular opportunities for enthusiasts and new players to play together, socialize and spread the enjoyment of the game.

You can find the Victoria Mahjong Club at:

Website: <http://www.victoriamahjongclub.com>
Facebook: <https://www.facebook.com/groups/victoriamahjongclub>
Bluesky: <https://bsky.app/profile/victoriamahjongclub.com>
Email: victoriamahjongclub@gmail.com